Department, went all out against any compromise: “The reform will be voted in full if you want it or not.” He vowed to put an end to the domination of the “elite,” those who participated in the Monday demonstration, with “their Rolexes and their Mercedes.” Amsalem, who is Mizrahi, pretends to fight against the Ashkenazi elite that, according to him, rules over the country and his brethren, those who work “as gardeners for the elite.” Amsalem is playing his usual vote-getting card, but it appears that a growing number of Likud Knesset members want a compromise.

Tuesday, February 14

A stormy meeting between Smotrich and the heads of the main Israeli banks. They tried to explain to the new minister of finance that the judicial reform is a danger to the economy. He apparently got angry and the encounter did not end well. The fact is that money is being transfered daily from Israeli banks to foreign ones.

In my opinion, Netanyahu’s decision to disregard foreign warnings and go for more settlements is clever: part of the protest movement is on the nationalist side and may become supportive of the coalition because of the settlements push. Let’s hope I am wrong.

From the beginning, the Zionist enterprise as perceived and supported by the majority of East European Jews—with the exception of “cultural Zionists” like Asher Ginsberg, known as Ahad Ha’am, “one of the people”—was intent on settling Eretz Israel by force, if necessary. The Arab population of Palestine was determined to resist this foreign invasion, also by force. As trouble started from the early years of Jewish colonization, some German Zionists like the sociologist Arthur Ruppin dreamed of cooperation with the local population in establishing a Jewish presence in the country and founded a movement to that effect: Brit Shalom, or “a covenant for peace.” Ruppin abandoned his peace project on the morrow of